

Autopsy Results & Timelines

How and when results are shared, what they can tell you, and how to ask your questions.

How results are shared

When the examination is complete, we prepare a written report. We will contact you, and we can walk through the findings with you in plain, everyday language. You are welcome to have family with you, or to bring a written list of questions — we expect questions, and we are glad to answer them.

How long it takes

Results take time. A preliminary picture may be available sooner, but the **final report often takes several weeks, and sometimes longer** — certain tests simply cannot be rushed without affecting their accuracy. We would rather be thorough than fast. We will keep you informed along the way.

What results can — and can't — tell you

- Sometimes results give a clear answer about the cause of death.
- Sometimes they give a partial answer, or confirm what was already suspected.
- Once in a while, no single cause can be found, even after careful examination.

Any of these outcomes can stir grief up again. That is a normal response, and support is available whenever you need it.

Questions are always welcome

There is no wrong question, and no expiration date on asking. If something in the report is unclear — then or months later — reach out and we will explain it.

To request a copy of the report or your loved one's records, see [**Medical Records & Death Certificates**](#).

Developed by the Central Autopsy Service at Henry Ford Health. An initiative led by **Pamela Holmes-Hill** and **Troy Shaffer**. Website and content by **Omar Z. Baba, MD**.